government quarter in south Delhi's Moti Bagh that was only eight kilometres from Rajiv Gandhi's official residence at 10, Janpath Road in New Delhi. It also worked because no one would view the occupants of a government quarter with suspicion.

Three sources confirmed the same crucial piece of information—Jayakumar and Payas, entries from Sivarasan's diary and Kanagasabapathy. The perfect murder was turning out to also be a perfect thriller for the SIT.

It was time to confront Athirai and Kanagasabapathy with the contents of the diary. Raju got Kanth in on the interrogation. The duo revealed that following instructions from Pottu Amman, Sivarasan set up a separate team to execute the assassination, in case he failed to strike at Rajiv Gandhi in Tamil Nadu. This was another stunning confirmation of what Jayakumar and Payas had revealed earlier. Athirai had shocked her interrogators by saying how much she regretted that another suicide attacker had succeeded in killing Rajiv Gandhi, depriving her of the chance of martyrdom. But Athirai maintained that she didn't know who could have been her target in Delhi. 'It was clear after what happened in Sriperumbudur,' she added.

Kaarthikeyan had stepped in at that moment and interchanged the interrogation teams. He asked Verma and Ragothaman to question Athirai and Kanagasabapathy and see if they could get a clue about what Sivarasan's next move would be. Likewise, he put Raju and Kanth before Payas, Peraribalan and Jayakumar all over again to see if they could dig up more on Sivarasan. Catching the mastermind was of paramount importance. Everything else could wait. And he took the responsibility of talking to Nalini and Padma himself to learn more about Sivarasan and the other human bomb, Shubha.

Athirai disclosed that the suicide-attack squad of the LTTE had carried out more than twenty-five suicide attacks, all within Sri Lanka. Rajiv Gandhi had been its first operation on foreign soil, for which three Black Tigresses were chosen—she, Dhanu and Shubha. She was the first of the lot to have been taken into custody by the Indian authorities. She gave them a name—Jagadeesan—whom, she said, had been assigned the task of